

Consent form

Annotate the main '*mechanism*' used and the main funny '*reason*' in each Chinese joke.

Information sheet:

Before you decide to participate in this annotation task, here's what I want to inform you: 1. The purpose of this research and 2. How the labeled data will be used.

This is a master's thesis research and the task here is to annotate jokes. In this scenario, it includes two main categories of annotation: how jokes are funny (the mechanism/device used in the jokes) and why they are funny. This task will be carried out by native Chinese speakers. The data collected in this study will only be used for research purposes.

You will be reading jokes that will not contain content that is offensive, harassing, or inappropriate for readers or annotators. However, if you come across sentences that are uncomfortable or questionable during the annotation process, please report such instances and the joke number after the annotation is complete.

Jokes annotated for this task will become a public resource, and the results of the entire study may be published on public platforms, scientific journals, or used for future research. Only essential statistical data of annotators will be disclosed, including native language, level of education, field of study, and nationality (Taiwan). All other personal details will remain anonymous.

Thank you.

In order to participate in this annotation task, you must:

- Be **a native Chinese speaker**.
- Be over eighteen years old and have the legal capacity to provide consent.
- Fully read and understand the above statements regarding this annotation and research.
- Agree that the data annotated in this task will be anonymously used for future research.
- Agree to participate in this annotation task.

If you meet the above criteria, please sign and date below: (Electronic Signature)

Instructions for Joke Annotation

Please note:

- You must be a native Chinese speaker.
- You have to complete all the annotation for each joke. All fields are required.

General Instructions:

The text for this annotation task consists of jokes, which may take the form of dialogues or written narratives. For each joke, you need to annotate it accordingly. There are two main categories: the first category is "how the joke is funny," which refers to the mechanism/device used in crafting the joke, and the second category is "why the joke is funny," which refers to the reasons why the joke is amusing as a whole.

- You may encounter jokes that belong to two or more categories simultaneously. In such cases, please rely on your own experience and judgment to select the most prominent or important category.

For example:

Health Tip: How to avoid feeling nauseous while brushing your teeth? Don't brush your teeth in front of the mirror.

This joke might use **irony** and **bridging inferences**. If you think the joke emphasize:

1. **associating** the connection between hidden setup and punchlines, which implies to “the person in the mirror is ugly”, opting for "**bridge inference**"
2. **alluding** that the person in the mirror is very ugly, then choose “**irony**.”

- You may encounter jokes where the mechanism or reason is ambiguous or difficult to define; annotate them as "**Others**." However, try to minimize the number of annotations with “**Others**.”

- Before annotating, clarify the difference between How classification and Why classification: for the categories of "how to make the joke funny", we are aiming to find linguistics mechanisms/ device used in jokes; while the categories of "why the joke is funny" are the reasons why the joke is humorous, identifying the punchline through that reason.

- Joke annotation is subjective and may vary depending on personal experience and learning background. So, do not worry, everything you make will be corrected.

Please read the above instructions carefully. If you have any doubts when annotating, please don't hesitate to come back to instructions or contact me. (hchihying001@ikasle.ehu.eus)

Thank you.

Annotation Guideline:

1. “How the joke is funny?”

The first part of annotation is about: the mechanism/device used in the jokes, which include twelve categories, listed as follows: exaggeration, illogical & contradiction, wordplay, insult, irony & sarcasm, bridging inferences, analogy, parody, personification, taboo/secret unveiling, job-telling and others.

• Please note: Each joke may use two or more techniques simultaneously, so please select **the most prominent, important, or primary technique for each joke to label** and minimize the use of **"Others"** where possible. The categories are listed below, along with detailed definitions, examples and explanation of each joke. Please read them carefully before starting the annotation.

1. **Exaggeration:** Using exaggerated words to describe things, including enlarging, minimizing, or anticipating exaggeration.

Example 1: My father told me a million times “never to exaggerate”. (The author exaggerates when he said “million times” to emphasize how many times his father has told him.)

2. **Illogical & Contradiction:** Actions or words in jokes that are illogical, contradict previous statements, or actually have no chance of happening in reality.

Example 2: “Whose banana peel is this?” said teacher. “I ate the banana, but I definitely didn’t eat the peel!” student replied. (It is impossible that people eat a banana that is originally without peel.)

3. **Wordplay:** Using 1. puns; 2. homonyms; 3. similar imagery, both "sounds, meanings, and images" are presented literally, to create sentences with dual meanings, achieving an effect of "pointing here but meaning there."

Example 3: **Homophones:** What did the fish say when he swam into a wall? Dam. (Dam and Damn are with same pronunciation.)

Example 4: **Polysemy:** What kind of tea is hard to swallow? Reality. (The last syllable of Real“ty” pronounces the same as tea. Tea also is slang for gossiping about a situation, story, news, or some juicy information.)

Example 5: **Similar imagery:** A matchstick’s head was itching so it scratched, and then... it caught fire. After the matchstick caught fire, it quickly ran to the hospital and turned into... a cotton swab. (A matchstick with bandage on top looks like a cotton swab.)

4. **Insult:** Using direct and derogatory language to attack someone, such as calling someone "fat, ugly, and useless."

Example 6: A woman boarded a bus with her baby. The driver looked at the child and said, "I've never seen such an ugly baby." Furious, the woman told a man next to her, "That driver insulted me!" The man replied, "Go confront him! I'll hold your ugly monkey." (Both the driver and the man implied that the baby was very ugly.)

5. **Irony & Sarcasm:** Using words that are non-literal, different from or opposite to their original meaning to criticize or ridicule, generally containing negative, sarcastic, and mocking meanings.

Example 7: “Can I have the name of your hair salon?” a man said to his friend, “I need to know where not to go.” (The man thinks his friend’s new haircut is ugly but we can’t tell this by literal description.)

6. **Bridging Inference:** Readers need to use "*Association*" to understand the joke. The joke hides the setup and the punchline's connection, meaning the punchline isn't funny on its own. It's through further association and inference between the punchline and the setup that the humor emerges. Unlike irony, this type of joke doesn't strongly or mostly imply a negative meaning.

Example 8: “You seldom drink outside.” wife said, “Why do you drink a lot at home?” “I was told that alcohol keeps me brave.” husband replied. (The relation between the question and the respond from the husband can’t be understood literally. Readers need to associate the implication of the joke (the relation of set up and punchline) is "The wife is too terrible to face without alcohol.")

7. **Analogy:** Drawing comparisons between several entities, regardless of whether the entities are related, logical, or not.

Example 9: A good spouse is a harbor for you to rest in a storm; a bad spouse is a storm in a harbor. (It compares “good spouse and bad spouse” by using the relationship of two same entities “storm” and “harbor”)

8. **Parody:** Utilizing famous quotes and classic words, intentionally changing their original meanings to make them more relevant to the current reality or situation.

Example 10: Fifty Shades of Earl Grey (Fifty Shades of Grey)

9. **Personification:** Employing personification or anthropomorphism, depicting humans as objects or non-human things in terms of human characteristics.

Example 11: One day, a toothpick was walking down the street when it noticed its shoelace was untied. As it bent down to tie it, the toothpick broke. (Make a toothpick as a human.)

10. **Taboo/Secret unveiling:** Including topics people usually avoid discussing openly. The jokes under this category reveal two scenarios: characters telling the truth with excessive honesty or directness, and situations where characters are caught off guard. These jokes typically involve unmasking, confession, or excessive honesty, making the situation embarrassing or comical.

Example 12: “Teacher, you say the Earth is constantly rotating, but I don’t feel anything.” student said, “However, my dad says he can sometimes feel it.” “Oh? How does your dad feel it?” teacher asked. “Whenever he’s had too much to drink.” student replied. (The kid reveals that his dad likes to get drunk.)

Example 13: His girlfriend wanted a balloon from the wedding car parked outside her house. With no one around, he took one. She asked for more. As he reached for another, the car door opened, and a guy inside said, "Hey buddy, leave some for me!" (Getting caught stealing balloons from the wedding car.)

11. **Job-telling:** The response aligns with the speaker's profession; however, the response isn't the typical way the general public would respond in that situation.

Example 14: John, who is a police officer, went hunting with his friends. Suddenly, he saw a deer. He quietly sneaked behind it, raised his gun, and shouted, 'Freeze! Put your hands up, or I'll shoot! (The police do this to a criminal when doing their job but he also did this to a deer.)

12. **Others:** Any joke elements that do not fit into the above categories are marked under others.

Here is a more detailed explanation of classification on HOW. For **Insult** and **Irony**, they both carry negative connotations. However, **Insult** involves directly using words in the joke that insult or attack someone (Example 6: "ugly"), while **Irony** is expressed indirectly, conveying a meaning that is different from or opposite to the literal words. Next, **Irony** and **Bridging Inference** both involve "not being able to directly understand the punchline from the literal meaning." Therefore, the definitions and distinctions here are: **Irony** includes implicit meanings and is often **negative** (Example 7: "ugly"), while **Bridging inference** requires associative thinking to infer the hidden punchline from the joke, and the jokes are mostly **non-negative** (or their nature as negative or positive cannot be determined).

- Please note: Since the process of association when understanding a joke is usually very quick and often imperceptible, if you believe that a joke might fall under **Bridging Inference** or a similar category, it is recommended to take a moment to confirm whether association is used to understand the joke.

2. “Why the joke is funny?”

The second part of annotation is about: the reasons why the joke is funny, which include seven categories (reasons), listed as follows: absurd and stupid behavior/utterance/situation, unexpected answer or situation, another implication, misunderstanding and missing the wrong point, pretending to know, accidentally make a clown of oneself, and others.

- Please note: Each joke may contain two or more reasons simultaneously, so please select **the most prominent, important, or primary reason for each joke to label** and minimize the use of "**Others**" where possible. The categories are listed below, along with detailed definitions, examples and explanation of each joke. Please read them carefully before starting the annotation.

1. **Absurd and Stupid behavior/utterance/situation:** In jokes, the protagonist says illogical or absurd things, or their actions are very foolish. Additionally, the situations in the jokes are often ridiculous or unlikely to happen in real life and that is why it is funny.

Example 15: A friend took out the flashlight he bought for over a hundred dollars and bragged, “It’s waterproof, believe it? I’ll throw it into the sea to prove it.” With that, he tossed it into the water. Everyone was quiet for a moment, then his wife shouted, “If you’re going to throw it, at least turn it on first!” (The main character did something stupid and makes the whole situation absurd.)

2. **Unexpected answer or situation:** The sudden change in attitude or punchline or a twisted development in a joke. This shift is typically unexpectedly linked to the previous statement, resulting in the punchline.

Example 16: Health Tip: How to avoid feeling nauseous while brushing your teeth? Please avoid brushing your teeth in front of the mirror. (Originally reader may think it is going to give some serious tip but turns out be implying reader is ugly.)

3. **Another implication:** Beyond the literal meaning, there's an implied meaning that makes the joke funny.

Understanding the humor often requires "association" and is usually found in the joke's final line.

Example 17: "Only after getting married, I started to realize the burden on two people." wife said "Since it is hard for two people, how about three?" husband replied. (The "three people" the husband refers to include his mistress. Literally, it seems like three people share the load, but it doesn't explain who the third person is in the marriage.)

4. **Misunderstanding or get the wrong point:** In jokes, whether intentional or not, misunderstandings arise between the protagonists due to different perceptions of the same thing. This leads to illogical or off-topic responses that make people laugh.

Example 18: I saw a man at the beach yelling "Help, shark! Help!" I just laughed; I knew that shark wasn't going to help him. (The man yelling was asking for the main character's help but the protagonist thought he was talking to shark.)

5. **Pretending to know:** The person in the joke doesn't understand others' meanings or doesn't know the real answer but still pretends to know and confidently responds. The humor here comes from the responder's ignorance and false confidence.

Example 19: Yesterday, at the park, I saw a rooster in the peacock enclosure and was puzzled. A nearby woman asked, "Why is there a chicken here?" Her partner replied, "It's to prevent peacock inbreeding." (His answer was illogical and baseless, yet he insisted on explaining it.)

6. **Accidentally make a clown of oneself:** The protagonist in the joke accidentally does something embarrassing or humiliating.

Example 20: Lunchtime was approaching, and a colleague was craving noodles. As a customer finished their transaction, the colleague, inadvertently, said, "Please take your noodles, and feel free to come again." (The protagonist accidentally referred to "money" as "noodles," potentially causing embarrassment for the character, as it was not intentional.)

7. **Others:** Any humor elements that do not fit into the above categories are marked under others.

3. Annotation in excel

You will receive an Excel file containing three columns (Joke, How, Why) with a total of 50 jokes. Start annotation sequentially in the How and Why columns. On the right side of each cell, you will see a downward arrow. Click on the arrow, and the categories for that classification will be listed sequentially. Reminder: Please select the category that you think best fits. (See example illustration below.)

	A	B	C
	笑話 Joke	如何 How	為什麼 Why
1			
2	健康小知識: 如何在刷牙時避免噁心乾嘔? 請不要對著鏡子刷牙了。	橋介理論	另有含義
3			明眼矛盾
4			意想不到的答案
5			童言童語
6			搞錯重點
7			另有含義
8			雙重意義
9			半斤八兩
10			職業病笑話
			不懂裝懂
			意外出糗
			其他

